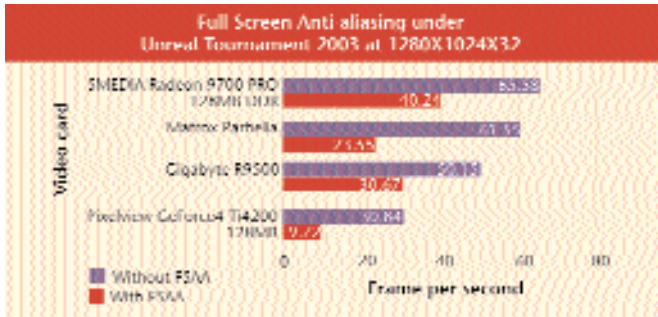




Similarly, the Parhelia at Rs 30,000 is outdone in performance by cards that cost half as much.

The game thus revolves around two players: nVidia and ATi. And the tables seem to be turning. While the budget solutions are still nVidia-chipset-based cards, ATi is capturing the high-end segment, thanks to feature-rich, high-performing variants of its DirectX 9.0-compatible R300 chipset. While we couldn't get our hands on a GeForce FX-based card, numbers flying around the Internet suggest that it is not a clear winner over the R9700 by far. Further speculations suggest that the R350 (ATI's answer to the FX) will not only cost less but also perform 10 to 20 per cent better. As it stands, an R9700-based card is our recommended choice for high-end gaming.

If you eat and breathe the frame rates and won't touch games without FSAA and Anisotropic filtering set to maximum, then look no further, **SMEDIA RADEON 9700** is the card that will quench your thirst. This card easily won our Best Performance Award. It is equipped with dual monitor capability and S-Video Out so you can watch high-quality movies on a television set. In *Quake III Arena* at 1280x1024x32 with settings kept at high, it logged a frame rate of 250.9 fps, which is not attainable by most of the cards in the market. The same was the case in DirectX-based 3DMark2001SE, where it touched 14692 3DMarks.

This figure gives an indication of the amount of power packed in this graphics card. The card also returned a very impressive 65.87 fps in *UT 2003* at 1280x1024x32 resolution.

Our Best Value Award goes to the **SMEDIA GeForce4 MX440**.

This card comes with both D-Sub and a DVI connector to connect two monitors to the PC and S-Video Out so you can enjoy the pleasure of a bigger screen. The card is well suited to those who want to play the latest games but don't mind disabling some features to get higher frame rates. The card gave some impressive results in our benchmarks. In *SeriousSam SE*, the card reached a high of 59.9 fps at 800x600 resolution. This means that the card can easily run most OpenGL-based games

such as *Jedi Knight II*. In *UT 2003* the card logged 60.88 fps at 800x600 resolution, which means that whatever kind of game you play, be it first person shooter or strategy game, it will simply fly with this card plugged into the system.

With a price tag of just Rs 3,900, this card is a steal.

ALIASGAR PARDAWALLA and AHMED SHAIKH

1/2 page Ver. AD



At Rs 16,000 the SMEDIA RADEON 9700 is the best gaming solution



A GeForce4MX chipset makes this SMEDIA card the best buy